# STRESS & BREATHING

**Recognizing stress, ways to bring it down in the moment, and habits that keep it manageable over time.**

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**SERIES** WELLNESS
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**GUIDE / VERIFY:** General wellness information, not medical or mental-health treatment. **If you are in crisis or thinking about suicide, call or text 988** (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, 24 hours). If someone is in immediate danger, call 911.

## 1. KNOW THE SIGNS

Stress is the body's normal response to pressure or danger. In short bursts it helps you act. When it doesn't let up, it wears you down. Common signs:

### BODY

- Headaches, tight muscles
- Upset stomach
- Trouble sleeping
- Fast heartbeat
- Tiredness

### MIND

- Worry that won't stop
- Trouble concentrating
- Forgetfulness
- Feeling overwhelmed

### BEHAVIOR

- Irritability, short temper
- Eating much more or less
- More alcohol, tobacco or other drugs
- Pulling away from people

## 2. IN THE MOMENT: FOUR TECHNIQUES

| TECHNIQUE | HOW | GOOD FOR |
|---|---|---|
| **Belly breathing** | Sit or lie down, one hand on your chest and one on your belly. Breathe in slowly through your nose so your **belly** rises (the chest hand stays still). Breathe out slowly through pursed lips. Repeat for 3 to 5 minutes. | Calming down anywhere; before sleep. |
| **Box breathing** | Breathe in for a count of 4. Hold for 4. Breathe out for 4. Hold for 4. Repeat 4 or more times. Shorten the counts if 4 is uncomfortable. | Steadying yourself under pressure: before a hard conversation, a test, or an emergency task. |
| **Muscle relaxation** | Starting with your feet and moving up: tense one muscle group for about 5 seconds, then let it go completely for 10 to 20 seconds. Notice the difference. | Physical tension; falling asleep. |
| **5-4-3-2-1 grounding** | Name 5 things you can see, 4 you can touch, 3 you can hear, 2 you can smell, and 1 you can taste. | Racing thoughts, panic, feeling detached. |

*If any technique makes you dizzy or more anxious, stop and breathe normally. These skills work better when practiced on calm days first.*

## 3. OVER TIME: HABITS THAT HELP

- **Move** every day; even a 10-minute walk helps. *(WL-01)*
- **Sleep** on a regular schedule. *(WL-06)*
- **Eat regular meals** and limit caffeine and alcohol.
- **Take breaks from the news** and social media, especially during a crisis. Check in at set times instead of all day.
- **Talk** with people you trust about how you feel. *(WL-08)*
- **Make time to unwind**: something you enjoy, every day.
- **Break big problems into small steps**, and do the next one. Preparing for emergencies can lower worry about them.

- **Notice what you can control**, and let go of what you can't.

> ! **GET HELP** if stress gets in the way of daily life for several weeks; if you feel hopeless, can't stop worrying, or are using alcohol or drugs to cope; or if you have thoughts of harming yourself. Talk to your provider, or **call or text 988**. For someone in immediate danger, call 911.

## 4. MY STRESS PLAN

| | |
|---|---|
| **My early warning signs** | |
| **What helps me calm down** | |
| **People I can talk to (name / phone)** | |
| **Things to avoid when I'm stressed** | |
| **Professional help (name / phone)** | |

### SOURCES / FURTHER REFERENCE

1. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention: Managing Stress; Coping with Stress After a Disaster. cdc.gov/mental-health
2. National Institute of Mental Health: I'm So Stressed Out! Fact Sheet. nimh.nih.gov
3. 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline. 988lifeline.org SAMHSA Disaster Distress Helpline: call or text 1-800-985-5990. samhsa.gov
4. MedlinePlus (National Library of Medicine): Stress and your health; relaxation techniques. medlineplus.gov

**IMPORTANT:** These techniques support, but don't replace, care from a qualified professional.